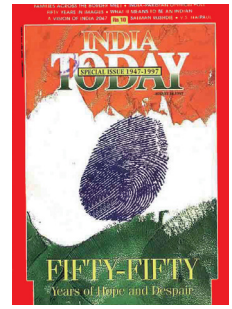
Nevertheless, even after achieving and retaining universal political freedom for 75 years, we have not liberated all our people from poverty. At the time of Independence, India's population was around 350 million and, being a poor country, we had over 200 million living below the poverty line. Despite over seven decades of economic development, which saw per capita income grow from a meagre Rs 365 to Rs 128,829 (still low by world standards), we continue to have over 240 million people living below the poverty line. Indeed, the population of the poor has dropped from 80 per cent to 20 per cent, but we still have as many poor people as the population of Indonesia. Also, the official definition of the poor is quite pathetic. A person who spends more than Rs 33 per day is not considered poor.

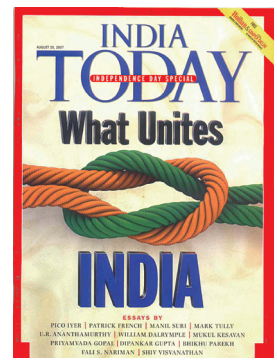


August 18, 1997



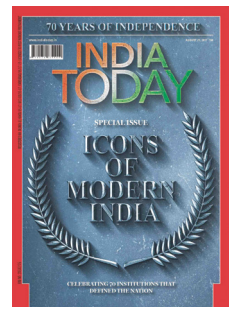
August 19, 2002

This, however, is not to detract from the enormous progress India has made in economic development by vastly improving the availability of basic necessities like food, housing, electricity, schools, water, roads and toilets. All this has resulted in life expectancy doubling from 32 years to 72 and the literacy rate more than quadrupling from 18.33 per cent in 1951 to the present 77.7 per cent.



August 20, 2007

The fact is that India straddles many centuries simultaneously. The country is divided into three layers. Experts say the upper crust has gotten wealthier over the decades. They have well-paid jobs, inhabit fancy dwellings, drive posh cars, travel abroad, own the latest gadgets and send their children to private schools. Generally, they live the life of the upper middle class of a developed country. According to the World Inequality Report 2022, the top 1 per cent in India hold 22 per cent of the national income and the top 10 per cent own 57 per cent of the wealth. Think of them as a privileged club of about 50 million.



August 21, 2017



August 30, 2021

Below that is a vast middle class, stratified into many layers. It is a broad swathe starting from the bottom end of the first category to those who lead barely adequate lives, just about living from EMI to EMI, from month to month, if not exactly hand to mouth. They struggle to pay the bills and simultaneously fund their children's education, but they have a roof over their head, plumbing, water, electricity, and all the basics. This segment is estimated to be about 400 million, more than the population of the USA. It is these two segments that drive India's consumer economy.

Under them, forming the broad base of the pyramid, are our urban slums and many of our villages, where people live hand to mouth on their daily income. This is the largest segment consisting of 900 million people. Almost one-third of them live without reliable access to water, electricity, toilets or modern health facilities. This huge mass of our citizens suffers from a complete lack of equal access to life opportunities—thus, any means to improve their lot. Dark systemic inertia keeps them in a place where children grow up stunted for want of proper nourishment. The numbers are getting less stark, but very slowly. The State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World 2022 report, conducted by a clutch of UN agencies and released in July, said the number of undernourished Indians had declined by 10 per cent over 15 years—but still to 224.3 million—in 2019-21. This is a shameful statistic for any country to have. This tragedy, too, is part of India. Therefore, the next 25 years must be unequivocally about economic growth and equity.

In this special issue, we look back at our passage through the decades with pictures and statistical snapshots of then and now—and celebrate our milestones in infrastructure, our remarkable progress in science and technology, agriculture and defence, our exotic tourism locations and exuberant cinema, and all the rest of what makes us tick as a people. But we also temper our enthusiasm with the sobering facts.

I believe in India. I believe in the people of India. They are talented, enterprising, creative, aspirational and, above all, resilient. Given a conducive environment where officialdom is not an obstructor but an enabler, there is nothing we cannot achieve. India has its own momentum and is changing rapidly. We have overcome food shortages, survived five wars, an Emergency, communal riots, separatist movements, terrorism, currency devaluation and demonetisation, venal politicians and chaotic politics. India is bigger than any party or politician. As we have seen in the past, it has its own self-correcting mechanisms. We live in a unique country. Let us celebrate our diversity and protect our hard-won freedoms.

Jai Hind.



(Aroon Purie)